

SONYA SILVA

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ABOUT ME

I am a researcher, facilitator, and service design consultant with over 15 years of experience leading teams, projects, trainings, and research initiatives in North America, the UK and Europe, East Africa, and South Asia. I use research, service design, and systems thinking to solve complex problems and deliver innovative services in the public, private, and non-profit sectors that help build more equitable futures.

EXPERIENCE

Senior User Experience Researcher

January 2024 - June 2026

User Experience Researcher

October 2022 - January 2024

Bloom Works

Remote

- Conducted co-design research in US government agencies on child welfare and protection. This included the development of an award-winning set of national standards to license kin caregivers for children in foster care, and delivering a maturity model toolkit on building a culture of family strengthening.
- Led user research strategy and methodology, participant recruitment, literature review, 1:1 interviews, surveys, and co-design workshops. Developed journey maps, process maps, and personas, alongside presentations, reports, and case studies that recommended future state designs.

Researcher & Youth Policy Consultant

November 2021 - January 2022

UN Department of Economic and Social Affairs (UN DESA)

Remote

- Researched and developed knowledge products on emerging issues in youth policy for the UN youth team, including two policy briefs on youth mental health and climate change, and peace and security.

Engagement Manager

August 2019 - October 2022

MLSE LaunchPad

Toronto, Canada

- Managed and designed a community engagement strategy in a sport for development organization to deliver meaningful participation for youth, parents, and communities. Oversaw the running of the youth advisory council, and how youth were consulted, engaged, and led initiatives within the organization.
- Led and delivered a virtual and in-person research symposium on youth mental health and movement. Coordinated the program and prepared youth speakers to facilitate panel and workshop discussions.
- Digitized food security and food skills programs through home delivery of fresh food boxes to families, and by producing online cooking classes, while retaining \$350K+ in sponsorship revenue.

Service Designer & UX Researcher Volunteer

May 2020 - September 2021

The Traveling Diary Tour

Remote

- Developed user flows, storyboards, user personas, affinity and emotional maps, and competitor analysis to communicate research insights and support the development and growth of the Traveling Diary.
- Designed a research plan and created survey and interview guides to collect and analyze user data.

Sri Lanka Operations Manager

February 2017 - October 2018

SLV.Global

Western Province, Sri Lanka

- Built the capacity of the operations department, including the planning of 1,500 volunteer placements.
- Oversaw the scheduling, training, and staffing for running psychosocial support sessions at 100+ project sites across 3 in-country offices.

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Volunteer & Evaluation Coordinator

October 2013 – January 2017

CRC (now amalgamated as Fred Victor)

Toronto, Canada

- Researched best practices and designed and led a volunteer program in a food security and housing organization that increased participant engagement in volunteer roles from 13% to 35% in two years.
- Designed and facilitated trainings and events, and a user-friendly handbook for over 200 volunteers.

Research Assistant

May 2013 – September 2013

Toronto Cycling Think & Do Tank, University of Toronto

Toronto, Canada

- Analyzed how cycling is perceived in developing countries and its relevance for cycling uptake among Canadian newcomers to Toronto, which was published in a local online magazine, *Spacing*.
- Examined the usability and navigability of a multi-use bike path in Toronto.
- Compiled and edited a report on comparative research on cycling plans across 11 cities.

Monitoring & Evaluation Manager

April 2010 – June 2012

Peace Child International

Buntingford, United Kingdom

- Published training materials and facilitated international workshops and events for youth-led development organizations on sustainability, advocacy skills, and monitoring and evaluation.
- Designed evaluations, analyzed data, and reported on a communication skills program run with 600 students in UK schools, and an international conference with 952 youth.

Researcher

May 2009 – September 2009

University of Toronto

Shinyanga, Tanzania

- Designed an ethnographic research project and secured funding to investigate the lived experience of people with albinism in Tanzania, focusing on the impact of discrimination on their lives.
- Conducted literature reviews, held interviews and focus groups, analyzed data, and reported the results.
- Recruited study participants including people with albinism, educators, doctors, partners, and local officials.

Program Assistant

October 2007 – July 2008

Presbyterian World Service & Development

Shinyanga, Tanzania

- Conducted research and identified gaps in participation and engagement in a food security project using participatory methods, including community mapping, wealth ranking, and qualitative interviews. This served as a mid-point evaluation and was published in a peer-reviewed journal.
- Prepared proposals for four new food security, water, school feeding, and HIV/AIDS programs for which funding was secured for projects with budgets between \$60K and \$360K.

EDUCATION

Master of Arts, University of Toronto

2012 – 2013

Anthropology & Collaborative Program in Women's Health

Toronto, Canada

Honours Bachelor of Arts, University of Toronto

2005 – 2009

Specialist in International Development Studies and Major in Anthropology

Toronto, Canada